

BUSINESS PLAN

TURNING THE TIDES

VETERAN RETREAT PROGRAM

Healing combat veterans through land, sea, and community.

FOUNDER: JOHN COLLINS
MAUI, HAWAII • A 501(C)(3) IN FORMATION
MAY 2026

Executive Summary

Turning the Tides is a 501(c)(3) nonprofit retreat program serving combat veterans living with PTSD. Our retreats — set on private farmland on the island of Maui, Hawaii — combine three evidence-backed therapeutic pillars: meaningful agricultural work, outdoor ocean and land activities, and small-cohort peer community.

Founded by John Collins, a U.S. Army infantryman who served two combat tours in Baghdad (2008 and 2010), Turning the Tides exists because of what helped him heal: not clinical settings, but other veterans, real work, and a place that felt like home. Our program is built to give that experience to others.

"I served two combat tours in Iraq. What helped me come home wasn't a clinic — it was other veterans, real work, and time on the land. I want every combat veteran to have that."

We serve combat veterans of any U.S. military branch dealing with post-traumatic stress, post-deployment readjustment, and the isolation that often follows. Retreats are always free for veterans, funded by grants, individual donations, corporate sponsorships, and paid civilian wellness retreats that subsidize the veteran program.

Year 1 Goals

- Run 2-3 pilot retreats serving 12-20 veterans
- Establish 501(c)(3) status
- Secure \$130,000 in funding
- Build operational infrastructure for scale

Year 3 Goals

- Run 6-8 retreats per year
- Serve 40-60 veterans annually
- Build a national alumni network
- Establish Turning the Tides as a leading agri-therapy retreat for combat veterans

Mission, Vision & Values

Mission

To empower combat veterans living with PTSD through immersive retreat experiences rooted in farm work, nature, and community — helping them reconnect with the land, with each other, and with themselves.

Vision

A future where every combat veteran has access to a supportive community and a healing environment to work through what they carry home — and where the strength they bring to that journey lifts up the next veteran behind them.

Core Values

- **Authentic Service** — Built by a combat veteran, for combat veterans. No clinical detachment, no condescension.
- **Honest Work** — Real labor that produces real results. The land doesn't care about rank or politics.
- **Aloha** — Genuine connection to the people, land, and traditions of Maui.
- **Always Free for Veterans** — Cost will never be a barrier to participation.
- **Privacy & Trust** — A veteran's story is theirs to tell. We protect, we don't disclose.

The Problem

Combat PTSD by the Numbers

20%

Of post-9/11 veterans experience PTSD (VA, RAND)

17/day

Average veteran suicides per day in the U.S.

2-4×

Higher PTSD risk for combat vs non-combat veterans

30+ days

Average VA mental health appointment wait times

Gaps in Existing Services

Conventional treatment options often fall short for combat veterans:

- Clinical settings can feel sterile and detached
- Group therapy with non-veterans struggles to address shared experience
- Pharmaceutical-only approaches manage symptoms but rarely address underlying disconnection
- Many veterans simply do not seek help — for reasons of stigma, distrust, or scheduling

What Veterans Tell Us Works

Repeated research and personal accounts (including the founder's own) point to:

- Peer connection with other combat veterans
- Physical work in nature — particularly farming and ocean activities
- Structured but pressure-free environments
- Time away from triggering daily contexts
- Cultural humility and warm hospitality

Program Overview

Turning the Tides operates 7-14 day immersive retreats for cohorts of 4-8 combat veterans at a time. The program rests on three pillars:

🌱 Pillar One — Farm & Land Work

Hands-on agricultural therapy partnering with local Maui farmers and agricultural cooperatives. Veterans participate in:

- Planting, harvesting, and tending traditional Hawaiian crops (kalo/taro, ulu/breadfruit, sugarcane)
- Care for livestock — chickens, goats, bees
- Building and maintaining farm infrastructure
- Preparing and sharing meals from food they helped grow

Therapeutic basis: Horticultural and agricultural therapy are evidence-backed interventions for PTSD, shown to reduce cortisol, restore daily routine, and rebuild a sense of purpose.

🌊 Pillar Two — Outdoor & Ocean Activities

Veterans engage with Maui's natural environment through surf instruction (Ho'okipa, Launiupoko, Lahaina), snorkeling at Kihei beaches, Molokini Crater, and Honolua Bay, outrigger canoe paddling, hiking Haleakalā summit, the Pipiwai Trail, and Iao Valley, plus whale watching, yoga, and stargazing.

Therapeutic basis: Physical activity in natural environments — particularly water-based — reduces hyperarousal and quiets the autonomic nervous system.

👥 Pillar Three — Community & Connection

Small cohorts of 4-8 veterans rebuild social connection and trust through shared meals, evening fire circles, peer-led discussions, one-on-one mentorship, integration with the local Maui community, and a post-retreat alumni network for ongoing connection.

Therapeutic basis: Peer support has consistently been identified as one of the most predictive factors in long-term recovery from combat PTSD.

Founder's Story

John Collins served two combat tours in Baghdad, Iraq with the U.S. Army Infantry — in 2008 and again in 2010. After returning home, he experienced post-traumatic stress in ways he was not prepared for. Like many combat veterans, the weight he carried home didn't show up on an X-ray.

What helped him turn things around wasn't a single program or clinical intervention — it was other veterans. People who had been there. Who didn't need explanations. Who simply understood. Combined with time on the land and the slower pace of life on Maui, that community became the foundation of his recovery.

Turning the Tides is built directly from that experience. The program isn't theoretical — it is a structured offering of the things that John knows worked for him, designed so other combat veterans can access them too.

Service Record

- **Branch:** United States Army
- **MOS:** Infantry
- **Combat Deployments:** Baghdad, Iraq — 2008
- **Combat Deployments:** Baghdad, Iraq — 2010

"I know what it feels like to come home from war and not know how to live in peace. Turning the Tides exists because of what saved me — and I want that for every veteran still fighting their invisible battle."

Operations Plan

Location & Facility

- **Land:** Private farmland on Maui, Hawaii (use granted by partner)
- **Capacity:** 4-8 veterans per retreat
- **Local partnerships:** Maui farms, surf instructors, cultural practitioners, transportation providers

Retreat Structure

- **Duration:** 7-14 days per retreat
- **Frequency Year 1:** 2-3 retreats
- **Frequency Year 3+:** 6-8 retreats annually
- **Cohort size:** 4-8 veterans
- **Daily rhythm:** Morning farm work → midday meal → afternoon outdoor activity or rest → evening shared meal and optional discussion

Staffing (Initial Phase)

- **Founder/Executive Director:** John Collins (full-time)
- **Retreat Facilitators:** 1-2 per retreat (paid stipend; ideally veteran peers)
- **Local Activity Partners:** Independent contractors for farm, surf, hiking
- **Volunteer Support:** Local community members for meals, hospitality, transport

Quality & Safety

- General liability insurance
- Medical clearance required for all participants
- Crisis response protocol — Veterans Crisis Line (988 press 1) and local emergency contacts on file
- All staff trained in basic mental health first aid

Financial Projections

Year 1 Budget Summary

Category	Annual
Startup & Legal Costs	\$5,000
Insurance	\$4,800
3 Pilot Retreats (lodging donated)	\$37,800
Founder Stipend — <i>deferred to Year 2</i>	\$0
Marketing/Outreach	\$5,700
Operations/Admin	\$3,900
Contingency (15%)	\$8,400
YEAR 1 TOTAL	\$64,600

3-Year Outlook

Year	Retreats	Veterans Served	Budget
Year 1 (Pilot — founder unpaid)	3	15-18	\$64,600
Year 2 (Build)	5	30	\$200,000
Year 3 (Scale)	8	48	\$300,000
Year 4	10	60	\$400,000
Year 5	12	72	\$500,000

Cost Per Veteran Served

Year 1: ~\$4,308 per veteran (with founder serving as unpaid volunteer). Year 3 (with founder paid): ~\$6,250 per veteran. By comparison, the VA spends ~\$11,000 per year on outpatient PTSD care for a single veteran.

Funding Strategy

Year 1 Funding Targets

Source	Target
Foundation Grants	\$60,000
Individual Donations	\$25,000
Corporate Sponsorships	\$20,000
Crowdfunding Launch Campaign	\$15,000
Founder/Personal Capital	\$10,000
TOTAL	\$130,000

Specific Grant Targets (Year 1)

Grant	Range
Bob Woodruff Foundation	\$10k - \$50k
Gary Sinise Foundation	\$10k - \$25k
Semper Fi & America's Fund	\$10k - \$30k
USDA Rural Development	varies
Local Hawaii Foundations	\$5k - \$20k

Long-Term Sustainability

Turning the Tides will diversify revenue across foundations, individuals, corporates, and earned income through paid civilian wellness retreats — using the same land and infrastructure between veteran retreats to generate revenue that subsidizes free veteran spots.

Implementation Timeline

Months 1-3 (Pre-Launch)

- File 501(c)(3) paperwork
- Recruit founding board (5-7 members)
- Set up bank account and accounting
- Secure insurance
- Land use agreement formalized in writing
- Launch crowdfunding campaign

Months 4-6 (Foundation)

- Apply for first 3 grants
- Recruit first cohort of veterans
- Lock in local partnerships (farm, surf, transport)
- Develop intake/screening process
- Hire/contract first facilitator

Months 7-9 (First Pilot)

- Run first retreat (4-6 veterans)
- Document everything
- Post-retreat survey/analysis
- Use data for future grant applications

Months 10-12 (Iterate)

- Run 2nd and 3rd retreats with refined program
- Apply for larger grants based on pilot data
- Begin alumni network formation

- Annual report and donor communications

Governance & Team

Founder

John Collins — Founder & Executive Director
U.S. Army Infantry, OIF combat veteran (Baghdad 2008, 2010)

Founding Board (To Be Recruited)

A 5-7 person founding board should include:

- A combat veteran with leadership experience
- A nonprofit operations professional (preferably with 501(c)(3) experience)
- A licensed mental health professional with veteran experience
- A finance/accounting professional
- A Hawaii-based community member
- A donor or major donor representative

Risk Management

Turning the Tides has identified and planned mitigation for operational, financial, and reputational risks:

- **Participant safety** — medical clearance, liability insurance, on-island medical access, crisis protocol
- **Mental health crisis** — partnerships with local providers, Veterans Crisis Line on file
- **Funding diversification** — never more than 30% from a single source
- **Cash flow** — 3-month operating reserve target by end of Year 1
- **Founder dependence** — strong board and program team

GET IN TOUCH

Let's Turn The Tide.

JOHN COLLINS

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